Janjua's ENGLISH LIT NOTES



A Christmas Carol

CHARLES DICKENS

EXAM EDITION

TEXT · MODERN ENGLISH · MODEL ANSWERS

BY QAISAR IQBAL JANJUA

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FREE SAMPLE



Every paragraph with modern English · every stave · model answers

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A Christmas Carol. Janjua's English Lit Notes.

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The text of A Christmas Carol is that of the first edition (Chapman and Hall, London, 1843), with obvious misprints corrected. That edition is in the public domain. The modern English paragraphs, notes, answers and all other material are original to this book.

Drawings: made for this book from the novel.

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The author used AI tools for research, drafting, the modern English paragraphs and the drawings, including the cover drawing, in preparing this book. Every quotation and paragraph number was then checked against this text, and every fact and answer against published sources, before publication.

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Sample: Stave One (Units 1 and 2) of the full Exam Edition. The whole book: janjuaslitnotes.com

How to Read This Sample

This sample is the first two units of A Christmas Carol: Exam Edition. The full book has every stave, ten units in all, with the twelve essays, the practice questions and the revision pages.

Staves. Dickens divides the story into five staves. A stave is a verse of a song, and Dickens uses the word because he calls the book a carol. Stave One is “Marley’s Ghost”.

Paragraph numbers. This book numbers every paragraph of the 1843 text, and every speech counts as one paragraph, however short. So the numbers will not match the pages of your own copy. Every fifth number is printed in red.

References. A quotation is followed by its stave and paragraph in brackets: (1.6) means Stave One, paragraph 6. Find the number in the margin of the text.

Modern English. Each paragraph of Dickens is followed by plain modern English, in grey type with a grey rule at its left. A short paragraph has its modern English directly beneath it; a long one is followed by its modern English as one paragraph. Quote Dickens’s words in the exam, never the modern English.

Word notes. The box marked WORDS explains old or hard words. Each note starts with its paragraph number.

The unit card. Each unit opens with a card: who and what the unit covers, three key points with quotations, and links to the answers. The coloured tags show the theme of each point: MONEY, CHANGE, POVERTY, FAMILY, CHRISTMAS and GHOSTS.

The answers. Each unit has a critical note (an answer of about 300 words on a character or a theme; a character sketch is a critical note on one person), three short answers (100 to 150 words each), and a context answer. A context answer explains a passage in four parts: **Reference** (who speaks, to whom, where), **Context** (what has just happened), **Explanation** (what the words mean) and **Critical comment** (why the passage matters).

Objective questions. Each unit ends with five objective questions. Choose one answer, (a), (b), (c) or (d). The keys, with a reason for each, are at the end. Four kinds of question need a word of explanation:

1. **Match the following.** Join each lettered line (A, B, C) to the right numbered answer (1, 2, 3), then choose the option that gives all the pairs correctly.
2. **Assertion and Reason.** Decide whether each sentence is true. Then decide whether the Reason (R) is the reason for the Assertion (A).
3. **Put in order.** Choose the option that lists the events in the order they happen in the story.
4. **Statement I and Statement II.** Decide whether each statement is true, then choose: only I, only II, both or neither.



Marley Was Dead: Scrooge in His Counting-house

STAVE ONE, PARAGRAPHS 1 TO 78 · THE COUNTING-HOUSE, CHRISTMAS EVE

On Christmas Eve, Scrooge turns away his nephew, refuses the two gentlemen collecting for the poor, and grumbles at his clerk's holiday.

Unit 1 · 78 paragraphs (2,932 words) · Essays 1, 3, 4, 10, 12 (full book)

Ebenezer Scrooge, drawn for this book from the novel.

1. The miser: "a squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, covetous, old sinner!" (1.6). MONEY
2. The nephew's belief: Christmas is "a kind, forgiving, charitable, pleasant time" (1.25). CHRISTMAS FAMILY
3. The poor who "would rather die" should "decrease the surplus population." (1.62). POVERTY

EXAMINERS ASK

Character sketch of Scrooge as Dickens presents him in Stave One. **Answer: Critical note, page 28**

How do the opening paragraphs about Marley's death set the tone of the story? **Answer: Short answer 1, page 29**

Explain the "surplus population" speech with reference to the context. **Answer: Context answer, page 31**

✓ **Dickens builds Scrooge out of cold, then tests him three times.**

In this unit: **Text 6** · **Critical note 28** · **Short answers 29** · **Context answer 31** · **Objective questions 32**

CONTEXT

The Poor Law, the workhouse and the counting-house. The Poor Law Amendment Act of 1834 grouped parishes into Poor Law unions, and each union had a workhouse. These are the "Union workhouses" (1.52) Scrooge asks about: the places where, in his words, "those who are badly off must go" (1.60). The Treadmill was the treadwheel, a prison machine introduced in 1818 by Sir William Cubitt. Scrooge pairs it with the Poor Law (1.54). The 1840s, when the story was written, were called the "Hungry Forties". A counting-house was an office for keeping accounts and doing business. Scrooge's counting-house still carries the name of a dead partner, "Scrooge and Marley" (1.5), and his clerk copies letters in a cell beside it.

The text

Stave I: Marley's Ghost

Marley was dead STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 1 TO 11

The narrator tells us that Marley is dead, and shows us Scrooge, his cold and greedy partner.

1 MARLEY was dead: to begin with. There is no doubt whatever about that. The register of his burial was signed by the clergyman, the clerk, the undertaker, and the chief mourner. Scrooge signed it: and Scrooge's name was good upon 'Change, for anything he chose to put his hand to. Old Marley was as dead as a door-nail.

> Marley was dead, to begin with. There is no doubt at all about that. The record of his burial was signed by the clergyman, the clerk, the undertaker and the chief mourner. Scrooge signed it, and Scrooge's name was trusted on the Exchange for anything he chose to sign. Old Marley was as dead as a door-nail.

2 Mind! I don't mean to say that I know, of my own knowledge, what there is particularly dead about a door-nail. I might have been inclined, myself, to regard a coffin-nail as the deadest piece of ironmongery in the trade. But the wisdom of our ancestors is

in the simile; and my unhallowed hands shall not disturb it, or the Country's done for. You will therefore permit me to repeat, emphatically, that Marley was as dead as a door-nail.

> Mind you! I do not mean to say that I know, from my own knowledge, what is especially dead about a door-nail. Left to myself, I might have thought a coffin-nail the deadest piece of iron goods in the trade. But the wisdom of our ancestors is in the saying, and my unholy hands shall not touch it, or the Country is finished. So you will allow me to repeat, firmly, that Marley was as dead as a door-nail.

3 Scrooge knew he was dead? Of course he did. How could it be otherwise? Scrooge and he were partners for I don't know how many years. Scrooge was his sole executor, his sole administrator, his sole assign, his sole residuary legatee, his sole friend, and sole mourner. And even Scrooge was not so dreadfully cut up by the sad event, but that he was an excellent man of business on the very day of the funeral, and solemnised it with an undoubted bargain.

> Did Scrooge know he was dead? Of course he did. How could it be otherwise? Scrooge and he were partners for I do not know how many years. Scrooge was his only executor, his only administrator, his only assign and his only heir to what was left. He was also his only friend and his only mourner. And even Scrooge was not so terribly upset by the sad event that he stopped being an excellent man of business. He celebrated the funeral by making a good deal that very day.

WORDS

1 'Change: **the Exchange in London, where merchants met** · **1** dead as a door-nail: **completely dead; an old saying** · **2** ironmongery: **iron goods, such as nails** · **2** unhallowed: **not holy; not blessed** · **3** executor: **person who carries out a dead man's will** · **3** administrator: **person who settles a dead man's affairs** · **3** sole assign: **only person his property passed to** · **3** residuary legatee: **heir to whatever was left over**

4 The mention of Marley's funeral brings me back to the point I started from. There is no doubt that Marley was dead. This must be distinctly understood, or nothing wonderful can come of the story I am going to relate. If we were not perfectly convinced that Hamlet's Father died before the play began, there would be nothing more remarkable in his taking a stroll at night, in an easterly wind, upon his own ramparts, than there would be in any other middle-aged gentleman rashly turning out after dark in a breezy spot—say Saint Paul's Churchyard for instance—literally to astonish his son's weak mind.

> The mention of Marley's funeral brings me back to where I began. There is no doubt that Marley was dead. This must be clearly understood, or nothing wonderful can come of the story I am going to tell. Suppose we were not sure that Hamlet's Father died before the play began. Then his night walk on his own castle walls, in an east wind, would be nothing strange. Any middle-aged gentleman might rashly go out after dark in a windy spot (say Saint Paul's Churchyard) and literally astonish his son's weak mind.

5 Scrooge never painted out Old Marley's name. There it stood, years afterwards, above the warehouse door: Scrooge and Marley. The firm was known as Scrooge and Marley. Sometimes people new to the business called Scrooge Scrooge, and sometimes Marley, but he answered to both names. It was all the same to him.

> Scrooge never painted over Old Marley's name. There it stood, years later, above the warehouse door: Scrooge and Marley. The firm was known as Scrooge and Marley. Sometimes people new to the business called Scrooge "Scrooge", and sometimes "Marley", but he answered to both names. It was all the same to him.

WORDS

4 Hamlet's Father: **the ghost in Shakespeare's Hamlet**

6 Oh! But he was a tight-fisted hand at the grind-stone, Scrooge! a squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, covetous, old sinner! Hard and sharp as flint, from which no steel had ever struck out generous fire; secret, and self-contained, and solitary as an oyster. The cold within him froze his old features, nipped his pointed nose, shrivelled his cheek, stiffened his gait; made his eyes red, his thin lips blue; and spoke out shrewdly in his grating voice. A frosty rime was on his head, and on his eyebrows, and his wiry chin. He carried his own low temperature always about with him; he iced his office in the dog-days; and didn't thaw it one degree at Christmas.

> Oh! But he was a tight-fisted, hard-driving man, Scrooge! A squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, greedy old sinner! He was hard and sharp as flint, from which no steel had ever struck a generous spark. He was secret, closed up and as solitary as an oyster. The cold inside him froze his old features, pinched his pointed nose, shrivelled his cheek and stiffened his walk. It made his eyes red and his thin lips blue, and spoke out sharply in his harsh voice. A white frost lay on his head, his eyebrows and his wiry chin. He always carried his own low temperature about with him. He chilled his office in the hottest summer days, and did not warm it one degree at Christmas.

7 External heat and cold had little influence on Scrooge. No warmth could warm, no wintry weather chill him. No wind that blew was bitterer than he, no falling snow was more intent upon its purpose, no pelting rain less open to entreaty. Foul weather didn't know where to have him. The heaviest rain, and snow, and hail, and sleet, could boast of the advantage over him in only one respect. They often "came down" handsomely, and Scrooge never did.

> Heat and cold from outside made little difference to Scrooge. No warmth could warm him, and no winter weather could chill him. No wind that blew was more bitter than he was. No falling snow was more set on its purpose, and no beating rain less open to pleading. Foul weather did not know how to get at him. The

> heaviest rain, snow, hail and sleet could beat him in one way only. They often "came down" generously, and Scrooge never did.

WORDS

6 flint: **hard stone that sparks when struck with steel** ·
7 "came down" handsomely: **fell heavily; also, gave money freely**

8 Nobody ever stopped him in the street to say, with gladsome looks, "My dear Scrooge, how are you? When will you come to see me?" No beggars implored him to bestow a trifle, no children asked him what it was o'clock, no man or woman ever once in all his life inquired the way to such and such a place, of Scrooge. Even the blind men's dogs appeared to know him; and when they saw him coming on, would tug their owners into doorways and up courts; and then would wag their tails as though they said, "No eye at all is better than an evil eye, dark master!"

> Nobody ever stopped him in the street to say, with a glad face, "My dear Scrooge, how are you? When will you come to see me?" No beggars begged him for a small coin. No children asked him the time. No man or woman, once in all his life, asked Scrooge the way to any place. Even the blind men's dogs seemed to know him. When they saw him coming, they would pull their owners into doorways and up side alleys. Then they would wag their tails as if to say, "No eye at all is better than an evil eye, dark master!"

9 But what did Scrooge care! It was the very thing he liked. To edge his way along the crowded paths of life, warning all human sympathy to keep its distance, was what the knowing ones call "nuts" to Scrooge.

> But what did Scrooge care! It was exactly what he liked. He pushed his way along the crowded paths of life, warning all human kindness to keep away. Those in the know would call that "nuts" to Scrooge.

10 Once upon a time—of all the good days in the year, on Christmas Eve—old Scrooge sat busy in his counting-house. It was cold, bleak, biting weather: foggy withal: and he could hear the people in the court outside, go wheezing up and down, beating their hands upon their breasts, and stamping their feet upon the pavement stones to warm them. The city clocks had only just gone three, but it was quite dark already—it had not been light all day—and candles were flaring in the windows of the neighbouring offices, like ruddy smears upon the palpable brown air. The fog came pouring in at every chink and keyhole, and was so dense without, that although the court was of the narrowest, the houses opposite were mere phantoms. To see the dingy cloud come drooping down, obscuring everything, one might have thought that Nature lived hard by, and was brewing on a large scale.

> Once upon a time, on Christmas Eve of all the good days in the year, old Scrooge sat busy in his counting-house. It was cold, bleak, biting weather, and foggy too. He could hear the people in the court outside wheezing up and down. They beat their hands on their chests and stamped their feet on the paving stones to warm them. The city clocks had only just struck three, but it was already quite dark. It had not been light all day. Candles flared in the windows of the nearby offices, like red smears on the thick brown air. The fog poured in at every crack and keyhole. Outside it was so dense that, though the court was very narrow, the houses opposite were mere ghosts. Watching the dirty cloud droop down and hide everything, one might think that Nature lived close by and was brewing on a large scale.

WORDS

8 up courts: **into narrow yards between buildings** · **8** an evil eye: **a look believed to bring harm** · **9** "nuts": **a great delight (slang of the time)** · **10** counting-house: **an office for keeping accounts and doing business** · **10** palpable: **thick enough to touch** · **10** mere phantoms: **only ghosts; faint shapes in the fog** · **10** brewing on a large scale: **making beer in bulk, like a brewery**

11 The door of Scrooge's counting-house was open that he might keep his eye upon his clerk, who in a dismal little cell beyond, a sort of tank, was copying letters. Scrooge had a very small fire, but the clerk's fire was so very much smaller that it looked like one coal. But he couldn't replenish it, for Scrooge kept the coal-box in his own room; and so surely as the clerk came in with the shovel, the master predicted that it would be necessary for them to part. Wherefore the clerk put on his white comforter, and tried to warm himself at the candle; in which effort, not being a man of a strong imagination, he failed.

> The door of Scrooge's counting-house stood open so that he could keep his eye on his clerk. The clerk sat in a gloomy little cell beyond, a kind of tank, copying letters. Scrooge had a very small fire, but the clerk's fire was so very much smaller that it looked like a single coal. He could not add to it, because Scrooge kept the coal-box in his own room. Whenever the clerk came in with the shovel, the master warned that they would have to part. So the clerk put on his white scarf and tried to warm himself at the candle. Not being a man of strong imagination, he failed.

WORDS

11 a sort of tank: **a cramped, closed space like a cistern** ·
11 necessary for them to part: **Scrooge would dismiss him** · **11** comforter: **a long knitted scarf**

The nephew's visit STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 12 TO 43

Scrooge's nephew wishes him a merry Christmas and invites him to dinner; Scrooge refuses.

12 "A merry Christmas, uncle! God save you!" cried a cheerful voice. It was the voice of Scrooge's nephew, who came upon him so quickly that this was the first intimation he had of his approach.

> "A merry Christmas, uncle! God save you!" cried a cheerful voice. It was the voice of Scrooge's nephew, who came upon him so quickly that this was the first warning Scrooge had that he was coming.

13 "Bah!" said Scrooge, "Humbug!"

> "Bah!" said Scrooge. "A fraud!"

14 He had so heated himself with rapid walking in the fog and frost, this nephew of Scrooge's, that he was all in a glow; his face was ruddy and handsome; his eyes sparkled, and his breath smoked again.

> This nephew of Scrooge's had so warmed himself by walking fast through the fog and frost that he was all aglow. His face was red and handsome, his eyes sparkled, and his breath steamed again.

15 "Christmas a humbug, uncle!" said Scrooge's nephew. "You don't mean that, I am sure?"

> "Christmas a fraud, uncle!" said Scrooge's nephew. "You do not mean that, I am sure?"

16 "I do," said Scrooge. "Merry Christmas! What right have you to be merry? What reason have you to be merry? You're poor enough."

> "I do," said Scrooge. "Merry Christmas! What right have you to be merry? What reason have you to be merry? You are poor enough."

17 "Come, then," returned the nephew gaily. "What right have you to be dismal? What reason have you to be morose? You're rich enough."

> "Come, then," the nephew answered cheerfully. "What right have you to be gloomy? What reason have you to be sour? You are rich enough."

18 Scrooge having no better answer ready on the spur of the moment, said, "Bah!" again; and followed it up with "Humbug."

> Scrooge, having no better answer ready at that moment, said "Bah!" again, and followed it with "A fraud."

WORDS

13 Humbug: **a fraud; nonsense meant to deceive**

19 "Don't be cross, uncle!" said the nephew.

> "Do not be angry, uncle!" said the nephew.

20 "What else can I be," returned the uncle, "when I live in such a world of fools as this? Merry Christmas! Out upon merry Christmas! What's Christmas time to you but a time for paying bills without money; a time for finding yourself a year older, but not an hour richer; a time for balancing your books and having every item in 'em through a round dozen of months presented dead against you? If I could work my will," said Scrooge indignantly, "every idiot who goes about with 'Merry Christmas' on his lips, should be boiled with his own pudding, and buried with a stake of holly through his heart. He should!"

> "What else can I be," the uncle answered, "when I live in such a world of fools as this? Merry Christmas! Away with merry Christmas! What is Christmas time to you but a time for paying bills without money? A time for finding yourself a year older, but not an hour richer? A time for balancing your books and finding every item in them, for a full twelve months, against you? If I could have my way," said Scrooge angrily, "every idiot who says

> 'Merry Christmas' should be boiled with his own pudding. He should be buried with a stake of holly through his heart. He should!"

21 "Uncle!" pleaded the nephew.
> "Uncle!" the nephew begged.

22 "Nephew!" returned the uncle sternly, "keep Christmas in your own way, and let me keep it in mine."
> "Nephew!" the uncle answered sternly. "Keep Christmas in your own way, and let me keep it in mine."

23 "Keep it!" repeated Scrooge's nephew. "But you don't keep it."
> "Keep it!" repeated Scrooge's nephew. "But you do not keep it."

WORDS

20 Out upon merry Christmas: **curse it; away with it** ·
20 stake of holly through his heart: **a wooden stake driven through the body** · **22** keep Christmas: **celebrate Christmas**

24 "Let me leave it alone, then," said Scrooge. "Much good may it do you! Much good it has ever done you!"
> "Then let me leave it alone," said Scrooge. "Much good may it do you! Much good it has ever done you!"

25 "There are many things from which I might have derived good, by which I have not profited, I dare say," returned the nephew. "Christmas among the rest. But I am sure I have always thought of Christmas time, when it has come round—apart from the veneration due to its sacred name and origin, if anything belonging to it can be apart from that—as a good time; a kind, forgiving, charitable, pleasant time; the only time I know of, in the long calendar of the year, when men and women seem by one consent to open their shut-up hearts freely, and to think of people below them as if they really were fellow-passengers to the grave, and not another race of creatures bound on other

journeys. And therefore, uncle, though it has never put a scrap of gold or silver in my pocket, I believe that it has done me good, and will do me good; and I say, God bless it!"

> "There are many things that might have done me good, but I have not gained from them, I dare say," the nephew answered. "Christmas among them. But when Christmas time comes round, I have always thought of it as a good time. I put aside the respect owed to its holy name and origin, if anything about it can be set apart from that. It is a kind, forgiving, charitable, pleasant time. It is the only time in the long calendar of the year when men and women seem to agree to open their shut hearts freely. They think of people below them as if they really were fellow travellers to the grave. They are not another race of creatures bound on other journeys. And so, uncle, it has never put a scrap of gold or silver in my pocket. But I believe it has done me good, and will do me good. And I say, God bless it!"

26 The clerk in the Tank involuntarily applauded. Becoming immediately sensible of the impropriety, he poked the fire, and extinguished the last frail spark for ever.

> The clerk in the Tank clapped without meaning to. At once he saw this was wrong, so he poked the fire and put out its last weak spark for ever.

27 "Let me hear another sound from you," said Scrooge, "and you'll keep your Christmas by losing your situation! You're quite a powerful speaker, sir," he added, turning to his nephew. "I wonder you don't go into Parliament."

> "Let me hear one more sound from you," said Scrooge, "and you will keep your Christmas by losing your job! You are quite a powerful speaker, sir," he added, turning to his nephew. "I wonder you do not go into Parliament."

28 "Don't be angry, uncle. Come! Dine with us to-morrow."

> "Do not be angry, uncle. Come! Dine with us tomorrow."

29 Scrooge said that he would see him—yes, indeed he did. He went the whole length of the expression, and said that he would see him in that extremity first.

> Scrooge said that he would see him, yes, he really did. He said the whole phrase: he would see him in hell first.

30 "But why?" cried Scrooge's nephew. "Why?"

> "But why?" cried Scrooge's nephew. "Why?"

31 "Why did you get married?" said Scrooge.

> "Why did you marry?" said Scrooge.

32 "Because I fell in love."

> "Because I fell in love."

33 "Because you fell in love!" growled Scrooge, as if that were the only one thing in the world more ridiculous than a merry Christmas. "Good afternoon!"

> "Because you fell in love!" growled Scrooge, as if that were the one thing in the world more absurd than a merry Christmas. "Good afternoon!"

34 "Nay, uncle, but you never came to see me before that happened. Why give it as a reason for not coming now?"

> "No, uncle, but you never came to see me before that happened. Why give it as a reason for not coming now?"

WORDS

26 the Tank: **the clerk's tiny cell; the narrator's nickname** ·
27 keep your Christmas: **celebrate Christmas; a joke on keep and lose** ·
29 see him in that extremity: **he would see him in hell first**

35 "Good afternoon," said Scrooge.

> "Good afternoon," said Scrooge.

36 "I want nothing from you; I ask nothing of you; why cannot we be friends?"

> "I want nothing from you. I ask nothing of you. Why can we not be friends?"

37 "Good afternoon," said Scrooge.

> "Good afternoon," said Scrooge.

38 "I am sorry, with all my heart, to find you so resolute. We have never had any quarrel, to which I have been a party. But I have made the trial in homage to Christmas, and I'll keep my Christmas humour to the last. So A Merry Christmas, uncle!"

> "I am sorry, with all my heart, to find you so firm. We have never had a quarrel that I took part in. But I have made the attempt out of respect for Christmas, and I will keep my Christmas mood to the end. So a Merry Christmas, uncle!"

39 "Good afternoon!" said Scrooge.

> "Good afternoon!" said Scrooge.

40 "And A Happy New Year!"

> "And a Happy New Year!"

41 "Good afternoon!" said Scrooge.

> "Good afternoon!" said Scrooge.

42 His nephew left the room without an angry word, notwithstanding. He stopped at the outer door to bestow the greetings of the season on the clerk, who, cold as he was, was warmer than Scrooge; for he returned them cordially.

> Even so, his nephew left the room without an angry word. At the outer door he stopped to give the clerk the greetings of the season. The clerk, cold as he was, was warmer than Scrooge, for he returned them warmly.

43 "There's another fellow," muttered Scrooge; who overheard him: "my clerk, with fifteen shillings a week, and a wife and family, talking about a merry Christmas. I'll retire to Bedlam."

> "There is another one," muttered Scrooge, who overheard him. "My clerk, on fifteen shillings a week, with a wife and family, talking about a merry Christmas. I will go off to Bedlam."

WORDS

38 humour: **mood, state of mind, not comedy** · **43** fifteen shillings: **a small weekly wage in old money** · **43** Bedlam: **London's hospital for the mentally ill**

The two gentlemen STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 44 TO 69

Two men collecting for the poor ask Scrooge for money. He refuses, and chases off a carol singer.

44 This lunatic, in letting Scrooge's nephew out, had let two other people in. They were portly gentlemen, pleasant to behold, and now stood, with their hats off, in Scrooge's office. They had books and papers in their hands, and bowed to him.

> This madman, in letting Scrooge's nephew out, had let two other people in. They were portly gentlemen, pleasant to look at, and now stood in Scrooge's office with their hats off. They had books and papers in their hands, and bowed to him.

45 "Scrooge and Marley's, I believe," said one of the gentlemen, referring to his list. "Have I the pleasure of addressing Mr. Scrooge, or Mr. Marley?"

> "Scrooge and Marley's, I believe," said one of the gentlemen, looking at his list. "Have I the pleasure of speaking to Mr Scrooge, or Mr Marley?"

46 "Mr. Marley has been dead these seven years," Scrooge replied. "He died seven years ago, this very night."

> "Mr Marley has been dead these seven years," Scrooge replied. "He died seven years ago, this very night."

47 "We have no doubt his liberality is well represented by his surviving partner," said the gentleman, presenting his credentials.

> "We have no doubt his generosity lives on in his surviving partner," said the gentleman, handing over his papers.

48 It certainly was; for they had been two kindred spirits. At the ominous word "liberality," Scrooge frowned, and shook his head, and handed the credentials back.

> It certainly did, for the two had been alike in spirit. At the threatening word "generosity", Scrooge frowned, shook his head, and handed the papers back.

49 "At this festive season of the year, Mr. Scrooge," said the gentleman, taking up a pen, "it is more than usually desirable that we should make some slight provision for the Poor and destitute, who suffer greatly at the present time. Many thousands are in want of common necessaries; hundreds of thousands are in want of common comforts, sir."

> "At this happy season, Mr Scrooge," said the gentleman, taking up a pen, "we should, more than ever, help the poor and destitute a little. They suffer greatly at this time. Many thousands lack the basic things they need. Hundreds of thousands lack ordinary comforts, sir."

WORDS

44 This lunatic: **the clerk, in Scrooge's mocking view** · **44** portly: **stout; large and round in body** · **48** liberality: **generosity; neither partner had any** · **49** destitute: **having nothing; very poor**

50 "Are there no prisons?" asked Scrooge.

> "Are there no prisons?" asked Scrooge.

51 "Plenty of prisons," said the gentleman, laying down the pen again.

> "Plenty of prisons," said the gentleman, putting the pen down again.

52 "And the Union workhouses?" demanded Scrooge. "Are they still in operation?"

> "And the Union workhouses?" Scrooge demanded. "Are they still working?"

53 “They are. Still,” returned the gentleman, “I wish I could say they were not.”

> “They are. Still,” the gentleman replied, “I wish I could say they were not.”

54 “The Treadmill and the Poor Law are in full vigour, then?” said Scrooge.

> “The Treadmill and the Poor Law are in full force, then?” said Scrooge.

55 “Both very busy, sir.”

> “Both very busy, sir.”

56 “Oh! I was afraid, from what you said at first, that something had occurred to stop them in their useful course,” said Scrooge. “I’m very glad to hear it.”

> “Oh! From what you said at first, I was afraid that something had stopped them in their useful work,” said Scrooge. “I am very glad to hear it.”

57 “Under the impression that they scarcely furnish Christian cheer of mind or body to the multitude,” returned the gentleman, “a few of us are endeavouring to raise a fund to buy the Poor some meat and drink, and means of warmth. We choose this time, because it is a time, of all others, when Want is keenly felt, and Abundance rejoices. What shall I put you down for?”

> “We believe they give the poor hardly any Christian comfort of mind or body,” the gentleman replied. “So a few of us are trying to raise a fund. We want to buy the poor some meat and drink, and some means of warmth. We choose this time because, more than any other, it is when Want is felt sharply and Plenty rejoices. What shall I put you down for?”

WORDS

52 Union workhouses: **workhouses run by the 1834 Poor Law unions** · **54** Treadmill: **the prison treadwheel, used since 1818** · **54** Poor Law: **the 1834 Act that set up union workhouses** · **57** Want: **poverty and hunger, pictured as a person**

58 "Nothing!" Scrooge replied.

> "Nothing!" Scrooge answered.

59 "You wish to be anonymous?"

> "You wish to be anonymous?"

60 "I wish to be left alone," said Scrooge. "Since you ask me what I wish, gentlemen, that is my answer. I don't make merry myself at Christmas and I can't afford to make idle people merry. I help to support the establishments I have mentioned—they cost enough; and those who are badly off must go there."

> "I wish to be left alone," said Scrooge. "Since you ask me what I wish, gentlemen, that is my answer. I do not make merry myself at Christmas, and I cannot afford to make idle people merry. I help to pay for the places I have mentioned. They cost enough, and those who are badly off must go there."

61 "Many can't go there; and many would rather die."

> "Many cannot go there, and many would rather die."

62 "If they would rather die," said Scrooge, "they had better do it, and decrease the surplus population. Besides—excuse me—I don't know that."

> "If they would rather die," said Scrooge, "they had better do it, and reduce the surplus population. Besides (excuse me), I do not know that."

63 "But you might know it," observed the gentleman.

> "But you could know it," the gentleman remarked.

64 "It's not my business," Scrooge returned. "It's enough for a man to understand his own business, and not to interfere with other people's. Mine occupies me constantly. Good afternoon, gentlemen!"

> "It is not my business," Scrooge replied. "It is enough for a man to understand his own business, and not to meddle in other people's. Mine keeps me busy all the time. Good afternoon, gentlemen!"

65 Seeing clearly that it would be useless to pursue their point, the gentlemen withdrew. Scrooge resumed his labours with an improved opinion of himself, and in a more facetious temper than was usual with him.

> Seeing clearly that it was useless to press their point, the gentlemen left. Scrooge went back to work with a better opinion of himself, and in a more joking mood than usual.

WORDS

59 anonymous: **with your name kept secret** · **62** surplus population: **extra people; often linked to Malthus, whom Dickens never names** · **64** business: **his trade, and also his concern**

66 Meanwhile the fog and darkness thickened so, that people ran about with flaring links, proffering their services to go before horses in carriages, and conduct them on their way. The ancient tower of a church, whose gruff old bell was always peeping slily down at Scrooge out of a Gothic window in the wall, became invisible, and struck the hours and quarters in the clouds, with tremulous vibrations afterwards as if its teeth were chattering in its frozen head up there. The cold became intense. In the main street, at the corner of the court, some labourers were repairing the gas-pipes, and had lighted a great fire in a brazier, round which a party of ragged men and boys were gathered: warming their hands and winking their eyes before the blaze in rapture. The water-plug being left in solitude, its overflowings sullenly congealed, and turned to misanthropic ice. The brightness of the shops where holly sprigs and berries crackled in the lamp

heat of the windows, made pale faces ruddy as they passed. Poulterers' and grocers' trades became a splendid joke: a glorious pageant, with which it was next to impossible to believe that such dull principles as bargain and sale had anything to do. The Lord Mayor, in the stronghold of the mighty Mansion House, gave orders to his fifty cooks and butlers to keep Christmas as a Lord Mayor's household should; and even the little tailor, whom he had fined five shillings on the previous Monday for being drunk and bloodthirsty in the streets, stirred up to-morrow's pudding in his garret, while his lean wife and the baby sallied out to buy the beef.

> Meanwhile the fog and darkness grew so thick that people ran about with blazing links. They offered to walk in front of carriage horses and guide them on their way. An old church tower had a gruff bell that always peeped slyly down at Scrooge from a Gothic window. Now the tower could not be seen. It struck the hours and quarters up in the clouds. Its sound trembled afterwards, as if its teeth were chattering in its frozen head up there. The cold became intense. In the main street, at the corner of the court, some workmen were mending the gas pipes. They had lit a great fire in an iron basket. Ragged men and boys gathered round it, warming their hands and blinking at the blaze in delight. The water-plug was left alone. Its overflow froze sulkily into ice that seemed to hate mankind. In the bright shops, holly sprigs and berries crackled in the heat of the window lamps. The light made pale faces red as they passed. The poultry and grocery shops became a splendid joke, a glorious show. It was almost impossible to believe they had anything to do with dull buying and selling. In the fortress of the mighty Mansion House, the Lord Mayor ordered his fifty cooks and butlers to keep Christmas as his household should. Last Monday he had fined the little tailor five shillings for being drunk and violent in the streets. Even this tailor stirred tomorrow's pudding in his attic, while his thin wife and the baby went out to buy the beef.

WORDS
66 links: **torches carried to light the way** · **66** water-plug: **a street water point, like a hydrant** · **66** Mansion House: **the Lord Mayor's grand official house**

67 Foggier yet, and colder. Piercing, searching, biting cold. If the good Saint Dunstan had but nipped the Evil Spirit's nose with a touch of such weather as that, instead of using his familiar weapons, then indeed he would have roared to lusty purpose. The owner of one scant young nose, gnawed and mumbled by the hungry cold as bones are gnawed by dogs, stooped down at Scrooge's keyhole to regale him with a Christmas carol: but at the first sound of

> Foggier still, and colder. Piercing, searching, biting cold. Saint Dunstan used his usual weapons on the Evil Spirit's nose. If he had only pinched it with a touch of weather like this, the Evil Spirit would truly have roared. One small young nose was gnawed and chewed by the hungry cold, as dogs gnaw bones. Its owner bent down at Scrooge's keyhole to treat him to a Christmas carol. But at the first sound of

68 "God bless you, merry gentleman! May nothing you dismay!"

> "God bless you, merry gentleman! May nothing trouble you!"

69 Scrooge seized the ruler with such energy of action, that the singer fled in terror, leaving the keyhole to the fog and even more congenial frost.

> Scrooge grabbed the ruler so fiercely that the singer fled in terror. He left the keyhole to the fog and to the frost, which suited it even better.

WORDS
67 Saint Dunstan: **saint said to have seized the Devil's nose** · **67** Evil Spirit: **the Devil** · **69** congenial: **well matched to Scrooge's cold nature**

The clerk's Christmas Day

STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 70 TO 78

Scrooge grumbles but gives his clerk Christmas Day off, and the office closes.

70 At length the hour of shutting up the counting-house arrived. With an ill-will Scrooge dismounted from his stool, and tacitly admitted the fact to the expectant clerk in the Tank, who instantly snuffed his candle out, and put on his hat.

> At last the time came to close the counting-house. Unwillingly, Scrooge got down from his stool. Without a word he admitted it to the waiting clerk in the Tank. The clerk at once put out his candle and put on his hat.

71 "You'll want all day to-morrow, I suppose?" said Scrooge.

> "You will want all day tomorrow, I suppose?" said Scrooge.

72 "If quite convenient, sir."

> "If quite convenient, sir."

73 "It's not convenient," said Scrooge, "and it's not fair. If I was to stop half-a-crown for it, you'd think yourself ill-used, I'll be bound?"

> "It is not convenient," said Scrooge, "and it is not fair. If I stopped half-a-crown from your pay for it, you would think yourself badly treated, I am sure?"

74 The clerk smiled faintly.

> The clerk smiled faintly.

75 "And yet," said Scrooge, "you don't think me ill-used, when I pay a day's wages for no work."

> "And yet," said Scrooge, "you do not think me badly treated when I pay a day's wages for no work."

76 The clerk observed that it was only once a year.

> The clerk remarked that it was only once a year.

77 “A poor excuse for picking a man’s pocket every twenty-fifth of December!” said Scrooge, buttoning his great-coat to the chin. “But I suppose you must have the whole day. Be here all the earlier next morning.”

> “A poor excuse for picking a man’s pocket every twenty-fifth of December!” said Scrooge, buttoning his overcoat to the chin. “But I suppose you must have the whole day. Be here all the earlier next morning.”

78 The clerk promised that he would; and Scrooge walked out with a growl. The office was closed in a twinkling, and the clerk, with the long ends of his white comforter dangling below his waist (for he boasted no great-coat), went down a slide on Cornhill, at the end of a lane of boys, twenty times, in honour of its being Christmas Eve, and then ran home to Camden Town as hard as he could pelt, to play at blindman’s-buff.

> The clerk promised that he would, and Scrooge walked out with a growl. The office was shut in an instant. The clerk had no overcoat, and the long ends of his white comforter hung below his waist. In honour of Christmas Eve, he went down an ice slide on Cornhill twenty times, at the end of a line of boys. Then he ran home to Camden Town as fast as he could, to play at blindman’s-buff.

WORDS

73 half-a-crown: **a coin worth two shillings and sixpence** ·
78 blindman’s-buff: **a chasing game played blindfolded**

Critical note

Character sketch of Scrooge as Dickens presents him in Stave One. (Frequently set)

Critical note · about 300 words

✓ **Answer.** In Stave One Dickens presents Scrooge as a miser frozen against every human claim: his dead partner, his nephew, the poor and his clerk.

Dickens builds him first out of cold. He is “a squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, covetous, old sinner!” (1.6), six words of greed in one breath. He is “solitary as an oyster” (1.6). That is a simile, a comparison using like or as, and it makes him shut and hidden. “The cold within him froze his old features” (1.6), and even “the blind men’s dogs” (1.8) avoid him. Scrooge wants this: “It was the very thing he liked.” (1.9). The fog outside (1.10) is pathetic fallacy, weather or nature made to share a mood.

Then Dickens tests him three times. His nephew says “A merry Christmas, uncle!” (1.12), and Scrooge answers “‘Bah!’ said Scrooge, ‘Humbug!’” (1.13). He refuses a dinner because the young man married for love. To the two gentlemen collecting for the poor he gives “Nothing!” (1.58). Those who would rather die, he says, “had better do it, and decrease the surplus population.” (1.62). He calls his clerk’s one day off “picking a man’s pocket every twenty-fifth of December!” (1.77). Each refusal is the same: other people are “not my business” (1.64).

Yet the portrait is comic as well as cruel. The narrator, the voice that tells the story, laughs at him: “Foul weather didn’t know where to have him.” (1.7). G. K. Chesterton wrote

Charles Dickens: A Critical Study (Dodd, Mead, 1906). He says that “Scrooge is not really inhuman at the beginning any more than he is at the end.” The jokes leave room for change.

Verdict: Scrooge in Stave One is cold by choice, the same in every refusal, and drawn with enough comedy that we expect him to change.

314 words

Short answers

How do the opening paragraphs about Marley’s death set the tone of the story?

Short answer 1 · 5 marks

✓ **Answer.** The opening paragraphs set a tone that is comic, confident and a little uncanny. Tone is the feeling a passage gives; uncanny means strange in a way that makes you uneasy. First, the narrator, the voice that tells the story, opens with a flat legal fact: “MARLEY was dead: to begin with.” (1.1). Then he jokes about the old saying that a man is dead as a door-nail, and chats to us like a friend. Second, the joke about Hamlet’s father is foreshadowing, a hint of what is to come. A ghost will walk, so we must believe in the death, “or nothing wonderful can come of the story” (1.4). Finally, Marley’s name is still painted above the door, as if he has not quite gone. Death, laughter and a ghost story meet on the first page.

139 words

What two attitudes to Christmas are set against each other in the quarrel between Scrooge and his nephew?

Short answer 2 · 5 marks

✓ **Answer.** The quarrel sets Scrooge's view of Christmas as a money matter against his nephew's view of it as a season of kindness. First, Scrooge measures the feast in his account books. For him Christmas is "a time for finding yourself a year older, but not an hour richer" (1.20). His test of happiness is wealth, so he says his nephew is too poor to be merry. Second, the nephew turns that test round: his uncle is rich enough to be merry. He calls Christmas "a kind, forgiving, charitable, pleasant time" (1.25). It has never put money in his pocket, yet he believes it has done him good. Finally, the clerk applauds, and the nephew leaves without an angry word. Dickens is on the nephew's side.

127 words

What does the treatment of the clerk show about Scrooge as an employer?

Short answer 3 · 5 marks

✓ **Answer.** Scrooge's treatment of his clerk shows an employer who buys work as cheaply as he can and resents every extra penny. First, the clerk works in "a dismal little cell beyond, a sort of tank" (1.11). His fire looks like one coal, because Scrooge keeps the coal-box in his own room. Second, the clerk keeps a wife and family on fifteen shillings a week. One clap for the nephew brings the threat that he will lose his job. Finally, a day's pay for Christmas Day is "picking a man's pocket every twenty-fifth of

December!" (1.77). Scrooge sees a man only as a cost. Yet the clerk goes home happier than his master, sliding down Cornhill twenty times.

119 words

COMMON MISTAKE

The mistake. Naming the clerk Bob Cratchit, or the nephew Fred, in a Stave One answer, or paying the clerk fifteen pounds. **The correction.** Stave One has only "the clerk" (1.11) and "Scrooge's nephew" (1.12); the names come in Stave Three. The wage is "fifteen shillings a week" (1.43). **Why it costs marks.** It shows careless reading.

Context answer

Stave One, paragraph 62

> "If they would rather die," said Scrooge, "they had better do it, and decrease the surplus population. Besides—excuse me—I don't know that." (1.62)

Reference to context · 200 to 250 words

✓ **Answer.**

Reference. Scrooge speaks these words in Stave One of A Christmas Carol by Charles Dickens. He is talking to one of the two portly, or stout, gentlemen who call at his counting-house on Christmas Eve.

Context. The gentlemen are collecting money to buy the poor "some meat and drink, and means of warmth." (1.57). Scrooge has asked whether the prisons, "the Union workhouses" (1.52) and "The Treadmill and the Poor

Law" (1.54) are still at work. Asked what he will give, he answers "Nothing!" (1.58). The gentleman objects: "Many can't go there; and many would rather die." (1.61).

Explanation. Scrooge takes the word "die" and turns it into arithmetic. If the poor would rather die than enter a workhouse, let them die: there are too many people, and deaths will "decrease the surplus population." He treats human beings as a figure too large in a ledger. Then he adds that he does not know this, and does not wish to: "It's not my business" (1.64).

Critical comment. This is the coldest line Scrooge speaks, and Dickens makes it the test of his change. The phrase "surplus population" is often linked to Thomas Malthus, an economist who wrote about population in 1798. The novel never names him. In Stave Three the Ghost of Christmas Present repeats these words to him. The line states what the three Spirits must undo.

234 words

Objective questions

Choose one answer. Keys are at the end of the book.

1. How long has Marley been dead when the story opens?

(a) One year
(b) Seven years
(c) Three years
(d) Ten years

2. Match the speaker with the line:
A. “What right have you to be dismal?”
B. “Are there no prisons?”
C. “If quite convenient, sir.”
D. “Many can’t go there; and many would rather die.”
Speakers:
1. Scrooge
2. The nephew
3. The clerk
4. One of the two gentlemen

(a) A-2, B-4, C-3, D-1
(b) A-1, B-2, C-3, D-4
(c) A-2, B-1, C-3, D-4
(d) A-2, B-1, C-4, D-3

3. Assertion (A): Scrooge refuses to let his clerk have Christmas Day off.
Reason (R): Scrooge thinks it unfair that he must pay a day’s wages for no work.

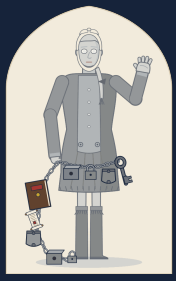
(a) Both A and R are true, and R explains A
(b) Both A and R are true, but R does not explain A
(c) A is true, but R is false
(d) A is false, but R is true

4. Put these events in the order they happen:
I. The two gentlemen ask for a donation.
II. A boy sings a carol at the keyhole.
III. The nephew wishes Scrooge a merry Christmas.
IV. The clerk goes down a slide on Cornhill.

(a) III, I, II, IV
(b) I, III, II, IV
(c) III, II, I, IV
(d) I, III, IV, II

5. Statement I: Scrooge never painted out Marley's name after his death.
Statement II: The clerk earns fifteen shillings a week.

(a) Only I is true
(b) Only II is true
(c) Both are true
(d) Neither is true



Marley's Ghost: "I Wear the Chain I Forged in Life"

STAVE ONE, PARAGRAPHS 79 TO 173 · SCROOGE'S CHAMBERS, CHRISTMAS EVE NIGHT

Scrooge sees Marley's face in the knocker. Then Marley's Ghost, dragging a chain of cash-boxes, warns him that three Spirits will come.

Unit 2 · 95 paragraphs (3,480 words) · Essays 1, 2, 6, 7, 8 (full book)

Marley's Ghost, drawn for this book from the novel.

1. The chain is made of "cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds, and heavy purses wrought in steel." (1.97). MONEY GHOSTS
2. "Mankind was my business." (1.148). POVERTY
3. The Ghost offers "a chance and hope of escaping my fate." (1.156). CHANGE

EXAMINERS ASK

Write a critical note on Marley's Ghost and the part it plays in warning Scrooge. **Answer: Critical note, page 61**

How does Dickens make the knocker and the Ghost both strange and believable? **Answer: Short answer 1, page 62**

Explain with reference to the context: "I wear the chain I forged in life," replied the Ghost. **Answer: Context answer, page 65**

✓ **Marley comes back not to frighten Scrooge but to warn him in time.**

In this unit: **Text 36** · **Critical note 61** · **Short answers 62** · **Context answer 65** · **Objective questions 66**

CONTEXT

A Ghost Story of Christmas. Dickens called the book a "Ghost Story of Christmas". He wrote it in the autumn of 1843, in about six weeks; it was published that December, the first of his Christmas books. He uses what readers expected of a ghost. Scrooge "remembered to have heard that ghosts in haunted houses were described as dragging chains." (1.93). The Ghost passes through a door that stays "double-locked" (1.173). The new thing is the purpose: this ghost comes to warn, and it sets out the plan of the story. The Ghost promises that Scrooge will be haunted "by Three Spirits." (1.158). It says they will come one a night, the first "to-morrow, when the bell tolls One." (1.163). Marley's fate is the lesson; the Spirits are the cure.

The text

The knocker and the stairs

STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 79 TO 96

Scrooge sees Marley's face in the knocker. Later the bells ring, and something comes through his door.

79 Scrooge took his melancholy dinner in his usual melancholy tavern; and having read all the newspapers, and beguiled the rest of the evening with his banker's-book, went home to bed. He lived in chambers which had once belonged to his deceased partner. They were a gloomy suite of rooms, in a lowering pile of building up a yard, where it had so little business to be, that one could scarcely help fancying it must have run there when it was a young house, playing at hide-and-seek with other houses, and forgotten the way out again. It was old enough now, and dreary enough, for nobody lived in it but Scrooge, the other rooms being all let out as offices. The yard was so dark that even Scrooge, who knew its every stone, was fain to grope with his

hands. The fog and frost so hung about the black old gateway of the house, that it seemed as if the Genius of the Weather sat in mournful meditation on the threshold.

> Scrooge ate his gloomy dinner in his usual gloomy tavern. He read all the newspapers, passed the rest of the evening with his bank book, and went home to bed. He lived in rooms that had once belonged to his dead partner. They were a gloomy set of rooms in a grim heap of building up a yard. It had so little business there that one could not help imagining a story. As a young house it must have run in there, playing hide-and-seek with other houses, and forgotten the way out. It was old and dreary enough now, for nobody lived in it but Scrooge. The other rooms were all let out as offices. The yard was so dark that even Scrooge had to feel his way with his hands, though he knew its every stone. Fog and frost hung thickly about the black old gateway of the house. It seemed as if the Spirit of the Weather sat on the doorstep, deep in sad thought.

WORDS

79 banker's-book: **his bank account book** · **79** chambers: **a set of rooms rented as lodgings** · **79** fain: **obliged; forced to** · **79** Genius of the Weather: **the spirit of the weather, as a person**

80 Now, it is a fact, that there was nothing at all particular about the knocker on the door, except that it was very large. It is also a fact, that Scrooge had seen it, night and morning, during his whole residence in that place; also that Scrooge had as little of what is called fancy about him as any man in the city of London, even including—which is a bold word—the corporation, aldermen, and livery. Let it also be borne in mind that Scrooge had not bestowed one thought on Marley, since his last mention of his seven years' dead partner that afternoon. And then let any man explain to me, if he can, how it happened that Scrooge,

having his key in the lock of the door, saw in the knocker, without its undergoing any intermediate process of change—not a knocker, but Marley's face.

> Now, it is a fact that there was nothing at all special about the knocker on the door, except that it was very large. It is also a fact that Scrooge had seen it, night and morning, all the time he had lived there. And Scrooge had as little imagination as any man in the city of London. That even includes (a bold claim) the corporation, aldermen, and livery. Remember too that Scrooge had not given one thought to Marley since he mentioned his partner, seven years dead, that afternoon. Then let any man explain to me, if he can, how it happened. Scrooge had his key in the lock of the door. In the knocker he saw, without any change in between, not a knocker, but Marley's face.

81 Marley's face. It was not in impenetrable shadow as the other objects in the yard were, but had a dismal light about it, like a bad lobster in a dark cellar. It was not angry or ferocious, but looked at Scrooge as Marley used to look: with ghostly spectacles turned up on its ghostly forehead. The hair was curiously stirred, as if by breath or hot air; and, though the eyes were wide open, they were perfectly motionless. That, and its livid colour, made it horrible; but its horror seemed to be in spite of the face and beyond its control, rather than a part of its own expression.

> Marley's face. It was not in deep shadow like the other things in the yard. It had a gloomy light about it, like a bad lobster in a dark cellar. It was not angry or fierce, but looked at Scrooge as Marley used to look, with ghostly spectacles pushed up on its ghostly forehead. The hair was strangely stirred, as if by breath or hot air. Though the eyes were wide open, they did not move at all. That, and its livid colour, made it horrible. But the horror seemed to be beyond the face's control, not part of its own expression.

WORDS

80 fancy: **imagination** · **80** corporation, aldermen, and livery: **London's city government, councillors and guild members** · **81** livid: **bluish grey, like a bruise**

82 As Scrooge looked fixedly at this phenomenon, it was a knocker again.

> As Scrooge stared hard at this strange sight, it was a knocker again.

83 To say that he was not startled, or that his blood was not conscious of a terrible sensation to which it had been a stranger from infancy, would be untrue. But he put his hand upon the key he had relinquished, turned it sturdily, walked in, and lighted his candle.

> It would be untrue to say that he was not startled. His blood felt a terrible feeling it had not known since he was a baby. But he put his hand back on the key he had let go, turned it firmly, walked in, and lit his candle.

84 He did pause, with a moment's irresolution, before he shut the door; and he did look cautiously behind it first, as if he half expected to be terrified with the sight of Marley's pigtail sticking out into the hall. But there was nothing on the back of the door, except the screws and nuts that held the knocker on, so he said "Pooh, pooh!" and closed it with a bang.

> He did pause for a moment, unsure, before he shut the door. And he did look carefully behind it first. He half expected to be terrified by the sight of Marley's pigtail sticking out into the hall. But there was nothing on the back of the door except the screws and nuts that held the knocker. So he said "Pooh, pooh!" and closed it with a bang.

85 The sound resounded through the house like thunder. Every room above, and every cask in the wine-merchant's cellars below, appeared to have a separate peal of echoes of its own. Scrooge was not a man to be frightened by echoes. He fastened the door, and walked across the hall, and up the stairs; slowly too: trimming his candle as he went.

> The sound rang through the house like thunder. Every room above, and every barrel in the wine-merchant's cellars below, seemed to have its own separate echoes. Scrooge was not a man to be frightened by echoes. He fastened the door, walked across the hall and went up the stairs, slowly too, trimming his candle as he went.

WORDS

84 pigtail: **a plait of hair, old-fashioned men's style**

86 You may talk vaguely about driving a coach-and-six up a good old flight of stairs, or through a bad young Act of Parliament; but I mean to say you might have got a hearse up that staircase, and taken it broadwise, with the splinter-bar towards the wall and the door towards the balustrades: and done it easy. There was plenty of width for that, and room to spare; which is perhaps the reason why Scrooge thought he saw a locomotive hearse going on before him in the gloom. Half-a-dozen gas-lamps out of the street wouldn't have lighted the entry too well, so you may suppose that it was pretty dark with Scrooge's dip.

> People talk loosely of driving a coach-and-six up a good old flight of stairs, or through a bad young Act of Parliament. But I mean that you could have got a hearse up that staircase. You could have taken it sideways, with the splinter-bar towards the wall and the door towards the balustrades, and done it easily. There was plenty of width for that, and room to spare. Perhaps that is why Scrooge thought he saw a hearse moving on by itself ahead of him in the dark. Half a dozen street gas lamps would not have lit the entrance well. So you may suppose it was quite dark with Scrooge's dip.

87 Up Scrooge went, not caring a button for that. Darkness is cheap, and Scrooge liked it. But before he shut his heavy door, he walked through his rooms to see that all was right. He had just enough recollection of the face to desire to do that.

> Up Scrooge went, not caring a button for that. Darkness is cheap, and Scrooge liked it. But before he shut his heavy door, he walked through his rooms to see that all was right. He remembered the face just enough to want to do that.

WORDS

86 coach-and-six: **a coach drawn by six horses** ·
86 through a bad young Act of Parliament: **a proverb: a bad law has large loopholes** · **86** hearse: **a carriage that carries a coffin** · **86** splinter-bar: **the cross bar the horses pull from** · **86** balustrades: **the banister rails of the stairs** · **86** dip: **a cheap candle dipped in tallow**

88 Sitting-room, bedroom, lumber-room. All as they should be. Nobody under the table, nobody under the sofa; a small fire in the grate; spoon and basin ready; and the little saucepan of gruel (Scrooge had a cold in his head) upon the hob. Nobody under the bed; nobody in the closet; nobody in his dressing-gown, which was hanging up in a suspicious attitude against the wall. Lumber-room as usual. Old fire-guard, old shoes, two fish-baskets, washing-stand on three legs, and a poker.

> Sitting-room, bedroom, lumber-room. All as they should be. Nobody under the table, nobody under the sofa. A small fire in the grate; spoon and bowl ready; the little pan of gruel (Scrooge had a cold in his head) on the hob. Nobody under the bed; nobody in the cupboard. Nobody in his dressing-gown, which hung against the wall in a suspicious way. Lumber-room as usual. Old fire-guard, old shoes, two fish-baskets, a washstand on three legs, and a poker.

89 Quite satisfied, he closed his door, and locked himself in; double-locked himself in, which was not his custom. Thus secured against surprise, he took off his cravat; put on his dressing-gown and slippers, and his nightcap; and sat down before the fire to take his gruel.

> Quite satisfied, he closed his door and locked himself in. He double-locked it, which was not his habit. Safe now from surprise, he took off his cravat. He put on his dressing-gown, slippers and nightcap, and sat down before the fire to eat his gruel.

90 It was a very low fire indeed; nothing on such a bitter night. He was obliged to sit close to it, and brood over it, before he could extract the least sensation of warmth from such a handful of fuel. The fireplace was an old one, built by some Dutch merchant long ago, and paved all round with quaint Dutch tiles, designed to illustrate the Scriptures. There were Cains and Abels, Pharaoh's daughters; Queens of Sheba, Angelic messengers descending through the air on clouds like feather-beds, Abrahams, Belshazzars, Apostles putting off to sea in butter-boats, hundreds of figures to attract his thoughts; and yet that face of Marley, seven years dead, came like the ancient Prophet's rod, and swallowed up the whole. If each smooth tile had been a blank at first, with power to shape some picture on its surface from the disjointed fragments of his thoughts, there would have been a copy of old Marley's head on every one.

> It was a very low fire indeed, nothing on such a bitter night. He had to sit close and lean over it to get the least warmth from such a handful of fuel. The fireplace was an old one, built long ago by some Dutch merchant. It was lined all round with quaint Dutch tiles showing scenes from the Bible. There were Cains and Abels, Pharaoh's daughters, Queens of Sheba, and angel messengers coming down through the air on clouds like feather-beds. There were Abrahams, Belshazzars, and Apostles putting out to sea in butter-boats. Hundreds of figures were there to catch his thoughts. And yet Marley's face, seven years dead, came like the ancient Prophet's rod and swallowed up the lot. Suppose each

> smooth tile had been blank, with the power to form a picture from the broken pieces of his thoughts. Then every tile would have shown a copy of old Marley's head.

WORDS

88 lumber-room: **a room for storing unwanted things** · **88** gruel: **thin porridge of oatmeal and water** · **88** hob: **a flat shelf by the fire for pans** · **89** cravat: **a cloth tied round the neck** · **90** the Scriptures: **the Bible** · **90** Cains and Abels: **pictures of Cain and Abel, Adam's sons** · **90** Pharaoh's daughters: **pictures of Pharaoh's daughter, who found Moses** · **90** Queens of Sheba: **pictures of the Queen of Sheba** · **90** Abrahams: **pictures of Abraham, the Bible patriarch** · **90** Belshazzars: **pictures of Belshazzar, a Babylonian king** · **90** butter-boats: **small boat-shaped dishes for melted butter** · **90** the ancient Prophet's rod: **Aaron's staff, which swallowed the magicians' staffs**

91 "Humbug!" said Scrooge; and walked across the room.

> "A fraud!" said Scrooge, and walked across the room.

92 After several turns, he sat down again. As he threw his head back in the chair, his glance happened to rest upon a bell, a disused bell, that hung in the room, and communicated for some purpose now forgotten with a chamber in the highest story of the building. It was with great astonishment, and with a strange, inexplicable dread, that as he looked, he saw this bell begin to swing. It swung so softly in the outset that it scarcely made a sound; but soon it rang out loudly, and so did every bell in the house.

> After walking up and down several times, he sat down again. As he threw his head back in the chair, his eye fell on a bell, an unused bell, that hung in the room. For some purpose now forgotten, it was linked to a room on the top floor. As he looked, he saw this bell begin to swing. He felt great astonishment and a strange dread he could not explain. It swung so softly at first that it hardly made a sound. But soon it rang out loudly, and so did every bell in the house.

93 This might have lasted half a minute, or a minute, but it seemed an hour. The bells ceased as they had begun, together. They were succeeded by a clanking noise, deep down below; as if some person were dragging a heavy chain over the casks in the wine-merchant's cellar. Scrooge then remembered to have heard that ghosts in haunted houses were described as dragging chains.

> This might have lasted half a minute, or a minute, but it seemed an hour. The bells stopped as they had begun, together. Then came a clanking noise deep down below. It was as if someone were dragging a heavy chain over the barrels in the wine-merchant's cellar. Scrooge then remembered hearing that ghosts in haunted houses drag chains.

94 The cellar-door flew open with a booming sound, and then he heard the noise much louder, on the floors below; then coming up the stairs; then coming straight towards his door.

> The cellar door flew open with a booming sound. Then he heard the noise much louder on the floors below; then coming up the stairs; then coming straight towards his door.

95 "It's humbug still!" said Scrooge. "I won't believe it."

> "It is still a fraud!" said Scrooge. "I will not believe it."

96 His colour changed though, when, without a pause, it came on through the heavy door, and passed into the room before his eyes. Upon its coming in, the dying flame leaped up, as though it cried, "I know him; Marley's Ghost!" and fell again.

> His colour changed though, when, without a pause, it came on through the heavy door and passed into the room before his eyes. As it came in, the dying flame leaped up, as though it cried, "I know him! Marley's Ghost!" and fell again.

Marley's Ghost STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 97 TO 130

Marley's Ghost stands before him in its chain. Scrooge tries to doubt it, then believes.

97 The same face: the very same. Marley in his pigtail, usual waistcoat, tights and boots; the tassels on the latter bristling, like his pigtail, and his coat-skirts, and the hair upon his head. The chain he drew was clasped about his middle. It was long, and wound about him like a tail; and it was made (for Scrooge observed it closely) of cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds, and heavy purses wrought in steel. His body was transparent; so that Scrooge, observing him, and looking through his waistcoat, could see the two buttons on his coat behind.

> The same face: the very same. Marley in his pigtail, usual waistcoat, tights and boots. The tassels on the boots bristled, like his pigtail, his coat-tails and the hair on his head. The chain he dragged was fastened round his middle. It was long, and wound about him like a tail. Scrooge looked at it closely. It was made of cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds, and heavy purses wrought in steel. His body was transparent. Looking through his waistcoat, Scrooge could see the two buttons on the back of his coat.

98 Scrooge had often heard it said that Marley had no bowels, but he had never believed it until now.

> Scrooge had often heard people say that Marley had no bowels, meaning no pity, but he had never believed it until now.

99 No, nor did he believe it even now. Though he looked the phantom through and through, and saw it standing before him; though he felt the chilling influence of its death-cold eyes; and marked the very texture of the folded kerchief bound about its head and chin, which wrapper he had not observed before; he was still incredulous, and fought against his senses.

> No, and he did not believe it even now. He looked the ghost through and through, and saw it standing before him. He felt the chill of its death-cold eyes. He noticed the very texture of the folded kerchief tied round its head and chin, a wrapper he had not seen before. Yet he still did not believe, and fought against his senses.

WORDS

97 tights: **close fitting breeches, worn with stockings** · **97** ledgers: **account books** · **97** deeds: **legal papers for property** · **97** wrought: **made; worked** · **98** bowels: **guts; in old usage, pity or a kind heart** · **99** kerchief: **a cloth tied round a dead person's jaw**

100 "How now!" said Scrooge, caustic and cold as ever. "What do you want with me?"

> "What is this!" said Scrooge, biting and cold as ever. "What do you want with me?"

101 "Much!"—Marley's voice, no doubt about it.

> "Much!" Marley's voice, no doubt about it.

102 "Who are you?"

> "Who are you?"

103 "Ask me who I was."

> "Ask me who I was."

104 "Who were you then?" said Scrooge, raising his voice. "You're particular, for a shade." He was going to say "to a shade," but substituted this, as more appropriate.

> "Who were you then?" said Scrooge, raising his voice. "You are fussy, for a shade." He nearly said "to a shade" (to the smallest degree). But "for a shade" (for a ghost) fitted better.

105 "In life I was your partner, Jacob Marley."

> "In life I was your partner, Jacob Marley."

106 "Can you—can you sit down?" asked Scrooge, looking doubtfully at him.

> "Can you, can you sit down?" asked Scrooge, looking doubtfully at him.

107 "I can."

> "I can."

108 "Do it, then."

> "Do it, then."

109 Scrooge asked the question, because he didn't know whether a ghost so transparent might find himself in a condition to take a chair; and felt that in the event of its being impossible, it might involve the necessity of an embarrassing explanation. But the ghost sat down on the opposite side of the fireplace, as if he were quite used to it.

> Scrooge asked because he did not know if so transparent a ghost could take a chair. If it could not, he felt, an awkward explanation might be needed. But the ghost sat down on the other side of the fireplace, as if he were quite used to it.

110 "You don't believe in me," observed the Ghost.

> "You do not believe in me," said the Ghost.

WORDS

100 How now: **old phrase meaning: what is this!** · **104** shade: **a ghost; "to a shade" means exactly**

111 "I don't," said Scrooge.

> "I do not," said Scrooge.

112 "What evidence would you have of my reality beyond that of your senses?"

> "What proof would you have of my reality beyond that of your senses?"

113 "I don't know," said Scrooge.

> "I do not know," said Scrooge.

114 "Why do you doubt your senses?"

> "Why do you distrust your senses?"

115 "Because," said Scrooge, "a little thing affects them. A slight disorder of the stomach makes them cheats. You may be an undigested bit of beef, a blot of mustard, a crumb of cheese, a fragment of an underdone potato. There's more of gravy than of grave about you, whatever you are!"

> "Because," said Scrooge, "a little thing affects them. A slight upset of the stomach makes them liars. You may be an undigested bit of beef, a blot of mustard, a crumb of cheese, a piece of underdone potato. There is more of gravy than of grave about you, whatever you are!"

116 Scrooge was not much in the habit of cracking jokes, nor did he feel, in his heart, by any means waggish then. The truth is, that he tried to be smart, as a means of distracting his own attention, and keeping down his terror; for the spectre's voice disturbed the very marrow in his bones.

> Scrooge was not much in the habit of making jokes, and in his heart he did not feel at all playful then. The truth is that he tried to be clever to distract himself and keep his terror down. The ghost's voice shook him to the very marrow of his bones.

117 To sit, staring at those fixed glazed eyes, in silence for a moment, would play, Scrooge felt, the very deuce with him. There was something very awful, too, in the spectre's being provided with an infernal atmosphere of its own. Scrooge could not feel it himself, but this was clearly the case; for though the Ghost sat perfectly motionless, its hair, and skirts, and tassels, were still agitated as by the hot vapour from an oven.

> To sit in silence for a moment, staring at those fixed glassy eyes, would, Scrooge felt, do him the very devil of harm. There was something awful, too, in the ghost having a hellish air of its own.

> Scrooge could not feel it himself, but it was clearly so. The Ghost sat perfectly still, yet its hair, coat-skirts and tassels still stirred as if in hot air from an oven.

WORDS

115 gravy than of grave: **a pun: gravy sounds like grave** · **116** waggish: **inclined to joke; playful** · **116** spectre: **a ghost** · **117** the very deuce: **the devil; to play the deuce: do harm** · **117** infernal: **of hell; hellish**

118 "You see this toothpick?" said Scrooge, returning quickly to the charge, for the reason just assigned; and wishing, though it were only for a second, to divert the vision's stony gaze from himself.

> "You see this toothpick?" said Scrooge, quickly going back to the attack, for the reason just given. He wished, if only for a second, to turn the vision's stony stare away from himself.

119 "I do," replied the Ghost.

> "I do," answered the Ghost.

120 "You are not looking at it," said Scrooge.

> "You are not looking at it," said Scrooge.

121 "But I see it," said the Ghost, "notwithstanding."

> "But I see it," said the Ghost, "all the same."

122 "Well!" returned Scrooge, "I have but to swallow this, and be for the rest of my days persecuted by a legion of goblins, all of my own creation. Humbug, I tell you! humbug!"

> "Well!" answered Scrooge. "I need only swallow this, and an army of goblins of my own making will torment me for the rest of my days. A fraud, I tell you! A fraud!"

123 At this the spirit raised a frightful cry, and shook its chain with such a dismal and appalling noise, that Scrooge held on tight to his chair, to save himself from falling in a swoon. But how much

greater was his horror, when the phantom taking off the bandage round its head, as if it were too warm to wear indoors, its lower jaw dropped down upon its breast!

> At this the spirit gave a terrible cry. It shook its chain with such a gloomy, dreadful noise that Scrooge held tight to his chair to stop himself fainting. But how much greater was his horror when the ghost took off the bandage round its head! It was as if it were too warm to wear indoors, and its lower jaw dropped down onto its chest!

WORDS

118 returning quickly to the charge: **going back to the attack** · **122** goblins: **small, ugly, mischievous spirits** · **123** swoon: **a faint**

124 Scrooge fell upon his knees, and clasped his hands before his face.

> Scrooge fell on his knees and clasped his hands before his face.

125 "Mercy!" he said. "Dreadful apparition, why do you trouble me?"

> "Mercy!" he said. "Dreadful ghost, why do you trouble me?"

126 "Man of the worldly mind!" replied the Ghost, "do you believe in me or not?"

> "Man of the worldly mind!" replied the Ghost. "Do you believe in me or not?"

127 "I do," said Scrooge. "I must. But why do spirits walk the earth, and why do they come to me?"

> "I do," said Scrooge. "I must. But why do spirits walk the earth, and why do they come to me?"

128 "It is required of every man," the Ghost returned, "that the spirit within him should walk abroad among his fellowmen, and travel far and wide; and if that spirit goes not forth in life, it is condemned to do so after death. It is doomed to wander

through the world—oh, woe is me!—and witness what it cannot share, but might have shared on earth, and turned to happiness!"

> "Every man must let the spirit inside him go out among his fellow men," the Ghost answered, "and travel far and wide. If that spirit does not go out in life, it is condemned to do so after death. It is doomed to wander through the world (oh, how wretched I am!). It must watch what it cannot share, but might have shared on earth and turned to happiness!"

129 Again the spectre raised a cry, and shook its chain and wrung its shadowy hands.

> Again the ghost gave a cry, and shook its chain and wrung its shadowy hands.

130 "You are fettered," said Scrooge, trembling. "Tell me why?"

> "You are in chains," said Scrooge, trembling. "Tell me why?"

WORDS

125 apparition: **a ghost; something that appears** · **126** worldly mind: **mind fixed on money and earthly things** · **128** walk abroad: **go out and about among people** · **130** fettered: **bound in chains**

The chain and the three Spirits

STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 131 TO 165

The Ghost explains its chain, warns Scrooge, and promises three Spirits.

131 "I wear the chain I forged in life," replied the Ghost. "I made it link by link, and yard by yard; I girded it on of my own free will, and of my own free will I wore it. Is its pattern strange to you?"

> "I wear the chain I made in life," replied the Ghost. "I made it link by link and yard by yard. I fastened it on of my own free will, and of my own free will I wore it. Is its pattern strange to you?"

132 Scrooge trembled more and more.

> Scrooge shook more and more.

133 "Or would you know," pursued the Ghost, "the weight and length of the strong coil you bear yourself? It was full as heavy and as long as this, seven Christmas Eves ago. You have laboured on it, since. It is a ponderous chain!"

> "Or would you know," the Ghost went on, "the weight and length of the strong coil you carry yourself? It was just as heavy and as long as this, seven Christmas Eves ago. You have worked on it since. It is a heavy chain!"

134 Scrooge glanced about him on the floor, in the expectation of finding himself surrounded by some fifty or sixty fathoms of iron cable: but he could see nothing.

> Scrooge glanced about him on the floor, expecting to find himself surrounded by some fifty or sixty fathoms of iron cable. But he could see nothing.

135 "Jacob," he said, imploringly. "Old Jacob Marley, tell me more. Speak comfort to me, Jacob!"

> "Jacob," he said, begging. "Old Jacob Marley, tell me more. Comfort me, Jacob!"

136 "I have none to give," the Ghost replied. "It comes from other regions, Ebenezer Scrooge, and is conveyed by other ministers, to other kinds of men. Nor can I tell you what I would. A very little more is all permitted to me. I cannot rest, I cannot stay, I cannot linger anywhere. My spirit never walked beyond our counting-house—mark me!—in life my spirit never roved beyond the narrow limits of our money-changing hole; and weary journeys lie before me!"

> "I have none to give," the Ghost replied. "It comes from other places, Ebenezer Scrooge, and other messengers carry it to other kinds of men. Nor can I tell you all I would. Only a very little more is allowed me. I cannot rest, I cannot stay, I cannot linger anywhere. My spirit never walked beyond our counting-house (mark me!). In life my spirit never wandered beyond the narrow limits of our money-changing hole. And weary journeys lie before me!"

WORDS
131 girded it on: **fastened it round myself** · **133** ponderous: **very heavy** · **134** fathoms: **measures of six feet each, for rope** · **136** ministers: **messengers; agents who carry something** · **136** money-changing hole: **scornful name for their own office**

137 It was a habit with Scrooge, whenever he became thoughtful, to put his hands in his breeches pockets. Pondering on what the Ghost had said, he did so now, but without lifting up his eyes, or getting off his knees.

> It was a habit with Scrooge, whenever he became thoughtful, to put his hands in his breeches pockets. Thinking over what the Ghost had said, he did so now, but without raising his eyes or getting off his knees.

138 "You must have been very slow about it, Jacob," Scrooge observed, in a business-like manner, though with humility and deference.

> "You must have been very slow about it, Jacob," Scrooge remarked, in a business-like manner, though humbly and respectfully.

139 "Slow!" the Ghost repeated.

> "Slow!" the Ghost said again.

140 "Seven years dead," mused Scrooge. "And travelling all the time!"

> "Seven years dead," Scrooge mused. "And travelling all the time!"

141 "The whole time," said the Ghost. "No rest, no peace. Incessant torture of remorse."

> "The whole time," said the Ghost. "No rest, no peace. Endless torture of guilt."

142 "You travel fast?" said Scrooge.

> "You travel quickly?" said Scrooge.

143 "On the wings of the wind," replied the Ghost.

> "On the wings of the wind," answered the Ghost.

144 "You might have got over a great quantity of ground in seven years," said Scrooge.

> "You might have covered a great deal of ground in seven years," said Scrooge.

145 The Ghost, on hearing this, set up another cry, and clanked its chain so hideously in the dead silence of the night, that the Ward would have been justified in indicting it for a nuisance.

> On hearing this, the Ghost gave another cry. It clanked its chain so horribly in the dead silence of the night that the Ward could fairly have charged it as a nuisance.

WORDS

137 breeches: **trousers, close-fitting and ending below the knee** · **141** remorse: **deep guilt and regret for wrongdoing** · **145** the Ward: **the city district and its officers** · **145** indicting it for a nuisance: **charging it in court with public disturbance**

146 "Oh! captive, bound, and double-ironed," cried the phantom, "not to know, that ages of incessant labour by immortal creatures, for this earth must pass into eternity before the good of which it is susceptible is all developed. Not to know that any Christian spirit working kindly in its little sphere, whatever it may be, will find its mortal life too short for its vast means of usefulness. Not to know that no space of regret can make amends for one life's opportunity misused! Yet such was I! Oh! such was I!"

> "Oh! Captive, bound, and chained twice over," cried the ghost, "not to know this! The good this world can do will take ages of endless work to bring out. Not to know that any kind Christian spirit, working in its own small world, will find life too short for all its good. Not to know that no amount of regret can make up for one life's chances wasted! Yet such was I! Oh! Such was I!"

147 "But you were always a good man of business, Jacob," faltered Scrooge, who now began to apply this to himself.

> "But you were always a good man of business, Jacob," Scrooge faltered, now beginning to apply this to himself.

148 "Business!" cried the Ghost, wringing its hands again. "Mankind was my business. The common welfare was my business; charity, mercy, forbearance, and benevolence, were, all, my business. The dealings of my trade were but a drop of water in the comprehensive ocean of my business!"

> "Business!" cried the Ghost, wringing its hands again. "Mankind was my business. The common good was my business. Charity, mercy, patience and kindness were all my business. The dealings of my trade were only a drop of water in the vast ocean of my business!"

WORDS

146 double-ironed: **chained twice over, hands and legs** · **148** forbearance: **patience; holding back from anger**

149 It held up its chain at arm's length, as if that were the cause of all its unavailing grief, and flung it heavily upon the ground again.

> It held up its chain at arm's length, as if that were the cause of all its useless grief. Then it flung it heavily on the ground again.

150 "At this time of the rolling year," the spectre said, "I suffer most. Why did I walk through crowds of fellow-beings with my eyes turned down, and never raise them to that blessed Star which led the Wise Men to a poor abode! Were there no poor homes to which its light would have conducted me!"

> "At this time of the rolling year," the ghost said, "I suffer most. Why did I walk through crowds of fellow beings with my eyes turned down? Why did I never raise them to that blessed Star which led the Wise Men to a poor home! Were there no poor homes its light would have led me to!"

151 Scrooge was very much dismayed to hear the spectre going on at this rate, and began to quake exceedingly.

> Scrooge was very much alarmed to hear the ghost going on like this, and began to shake terribly.

152 "Hear me!" cried the Ghost. "My time is nearly gone."

> "Listen to me!" cried the Ghost. "My time is nearly gone."

153 "I will," said Scrooge. "But don't be hard upon me! Don't be flowery, Jacob! Pray!"

> "I will," said Scrooge. "But do not be hard on me! Do not be flowery, Jacob! Please!"

154 "How it is that I appear before you in a shape that you can see, I may not tell. I have sat invisible beside you many and many a day."

> "How it is that I appear before you in a shape you can see, I may not tell. I have sat unseen beside you many and many a day."

WORDS

150 that blessed Star: **the Star of Bethlehem in the Nativity** · **150** the Wise Men: **the Magi who visited the infant Jesus** · **153** flowery: **using grand, fancy language**

155 It was not an agreeable idea. Scrooge shivered, and wiped the perspiration from his brow.

> It was not a pleasant idea. Scrooge shivered, and wiped the sweat from his forehead.

156 "That is no light part of my penance," pursued the Ghost. "I am here to-night to warn you, that you have yet a chance and hope of escaping my fate. A chance and hope of my procuring, Ebenezer."

> "That is no small part of my punishment," the Ghost went on. "I am here tonight to warn you that you still have a chance and hope of escaping my fate. A chance and hope I have won for you, Ebenezer."

157 "You were always a good friend to me," said Scrooge. "Thank'ee!"

> "You were always a good friend to me," said Scrooge. "Thank you!"

158 "You will be haunted," resumed the Ghost, "by Three Spirits."

> "You will be haunted," the Ghost continued, "by Three Spirits."

159 Scrooge's countenance fell almost as low as the Ghost's had done.

> Scrooge's face fell almost as low as the Ghost's had done.

160 "Is that the chance and hope you mentioned, Jacob?" he demanded, in a faltering voice.

> "Is that the chance and hope you mentioned, Jacob?" he asked, in a faltering voice.

161 "It is."

> "It is."

162 "I—I think I'd rather not," said Scrooge.

> "I, I think I would rather not," said Scrooge.

163 "Without their visits," said the Ghost, "you cannot hope to shun the path I tread. Expect the first to-morrow, when the bell tolls One."

> "Without their visits," said the Ghost, "you cannot hope to avoid the path I walk. Expect the first tomorrow, when the bell strikes One."

164 "Couldn't I take 'em all at once, and have it over, Jacob?" hinted Scrooge.

> "Could I not take them all at once, and have it over, Jacob?" Scrooge hinted.

165 "Expect the second on the next night at the same hour. The third upon the next night when the last stroke of Twelve has ceased to vibrate. Look to see me no more; and look that, for your own sake, you remember what has passed between us!"

> "Expect the second on the next night at the same hour. The third on the night after, when the last stroke of Twelve has stopped ringing. Look to see me no more; and for your own sake, see that you remember what has passed between us!"

WORDS

156 penance: **punishment to make up for sin** · **156** of my procuring: **that I have obtained for you**

The phantoms at the window

STAVE ONE · PARAGRAPHS 166 TO 173

Through the window Scrooge sees the air full of chained, moaning phantoms. Then he sleeps.

166 When it had said these words, the spectre took its wrapper from the table, and bound it round its head, as before. Scrooge knew this, by the smart sound its teeth made, when the jaws were brought together by the bandage. He ventured to raise his eyes again, and found his supernatural visitor confronting him in an erect attitude, with its chain wound over and about its arm.

> When it had said these words, the ghost took its wrapper from the table and tied it round its head as before. Scrooge knew this by the sharp sound its teeth made when the bandage brought the jaws together. He dared to raise his eyes again. His supernatural visitor stood upright facing him, with its chain wound over and around its arm.

167 The apparition walked backward from him; and at every step it took, the window raised itself a little, so that when the spectre reached it, it was wide open.

> The ghost walked backwards away from him. At every step it took, the window raised itself a little, so that when the ghost reached it, it was wide open.

168 It beckoned Scrooge to approach, which he did. When they were within two paces of each other, Marley's Ghost held up its hand, warning him to come no nearer. Scrooge stopped.

> It beckoned Scrooge to come closer, and he did. When they were within two steps of each other, Marley's Ghost held up its hand, warning him to come no nearer. Scrooge stopped.

169 Not so much in obedience, as in surprise and fear: for on the raising of the hand, he became sensible of confused noises in the air; incoherent sounds of lamentation and regret; wailings inexpressibly sorrowful and self-accusatory. The spectre, after listening for a moment, joined in the mournful dirge; and floated out upon the bleak, dark night.

> It was not so much obedience as surprise and fear. When the hand was raised, he became aware of confused noises in the air. They were broken sounds of grief and regret, wailings unspeakably sad and full of self-blame. The ghost listened for a moment, then joined in the mournful dirge. It floated out into the bleak, dark night.

WORDS

166 wrapper: **the cloth bandage round its jaw** · **169** dirge: **a song of mourning for the dead**

170 Scrooge followed to the window: desperate in his curiosity. He looked out.

> Scrooge followed to the window, desperate with curiosity. He looked out.

171 The air was filled with phantoms, wandering hither and thither in restless haste, and moaning as they went. Every one of them wore chains like Marley's Ghost; some few (they might be guilty governments) were linked together; none were free. Many had been personally known to Scrooge in their lives. He had been quite familiar with one old ghost, in a white waistcoat, with a monstrous iron safe attached to its ankle, who cried piteously at being unable to assist a wretched woman with an infant, whom it saw below, upon a door-step. The misery with them all was, clearly, that they sought to interfere, for good, in human matters, and had lost the power for ever.

> The air was full of ghosts, wandering here and there in restless haste and moaning as they went. Every one of them wore chains like Marley's Ghost. A few (they might be guilty governments) were linked together. None were free. Many had been known to

> Scrooge in their lives. He had known one old ghost quite well, in a white waistcoat, with a huge iron safe fastened to its ankle. It cried pitifully because it could not help a wretched woman and her baby, whom it saw below on a doorstep. The misery of them all was clearly that they wanted to do good in human affairs, and had lost the power for ever.

172 Whether these creatures faded into mist, or mist enshrouded them, he could not tell. But they and their spirit voices faded together; and the night became as it had been when he walked home.

> Whether these creatures faded into mist, or mist wrapped them round, he could not tell. But they and their spirit voices faded together, and the night became as it had been when he walked home.

173 Scrooge closed the window, and examined the door by which the Ghost had entered. It was double-locked, as he had locked it with his own hands, and the bolts were undisturbed. He tried to say "Humbug!" but stopped at the first syllable. And being, from the emotion he had undergone, or the fatigues of the day, or his glimpse of the Invisible World, or the dull conversation of the Ghost, or the lateness of the hour, much in need of repose; went straight to bed, without undressing, and fell asleep upon the instant.

> Scrooge closed the window and examined the door by which the Ghost had come in. It was double-locked, as he had locked it with his own hands, and the bolts were untouched. He tried to say "A fraud!" but stopped at the first sound. He was much in need of rest. It might be from the emotion he had been through, or the tiredness of the day. It might be his glimpse of the Invisible World, or the Ghost's dull talk, or the late hour. So he went straight to bed without undressing, and fell asleep at once.

WORDS

173 Invisible World: **the world of spirits**

Critical note

Write a critical note on Marley's Ghost and the part it plays in warning Scrooge. (Frequently set)

Critical note · about 300 words

✓ **Answer.** Marley's Ghost is the first of Scrooge's supernatural visitors, and its part is to warn. It shows Scrooge his own future, explains the law behind it, and promises the three Spirits who can save him.

First, the Ghost is a mirror. It is Marley as he lived, "in his pigtail, usual waistcoat, tights and boots" (1.97). It was Scrooge's partner in the same "money-changing hole" (1.136). Its chain is made of "cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds, and heavy purses wrought in steel." (1.97). These are the tools of their trade: account books, legal papers and money. When Scrooge looks at it, he looks at himself.

Second, the Ghost states the moral law of the story. A spirit that "goes not forth in life" (1.128) must wander after death and watch the happiness it never shared. The chain is self-made: "I wear the chain I forged in life" (1.131). Scrooge's own was "full as heavy and as long as this, seven Christmas Eves ago." (1.133), and it has grown since. The cry "Mankind was my business." (1.148) answers Scrooge's belief that business means only money.

Third, the Ghost gives hope. It has come "to warn you, that you have yet a chance and hope of escaping my fate." (1.156). The chance is the three Spirits, promised one a night. Without them Scrooge "cannot hope to shun the path I tread." (1.163).

Dickens keeps the scene human with Scrooge's jokes, "more of gravy than of grave" (1.115). Yet terror wins, and Scrooge "fell upon his knees" (1.124). G. K. Chesterton wrote Charles Dickens: A Critical Study (Dodd, Mead, 1906). He says of the story: "Whether the Christmas visions would or would not convert Scrooge, they convert us." The warning is meant for the reader too.

Verdict: Marley's Ghost is the warning that makes the story possible: it names Scrooge's disease and prescribes the cure.

323 words

Short answers

How does Dickens make the knocker and the Ghost both strange and believable?

Short answer 1 · 5 marks

✓ **Answer.** Dickens makes the knocker and the Ghost believable by setting each strange thing among plain facts and Scrooge's own doubt. First, the narrator, the voice that tells the story, insists that the knocker was ordinary. There was "nothing at all particular about the knocker on the door, except that it was very large." (1.80). Second, the face is described with everyday exactness. It glows "like a bad lobster in a dark cellar." (1.81). This simile, a comparison using like or as, is plain rather than grand. Finally, the Ghost is just as exact: Scrooge can see the two buttons on its coat through its body. Scrooge doubts his senses and blames his stomach, so the reader believes before he does. The strangeness convinces because the details are ordinary.

130 words

What is the meaning of the chain that Marley's Ghost wears?

Short answer 2 · 5 marks

✓ **Answer.** The chain is the record of a wasted life, made by the man who wears it. First, it is built of the things Marley lived for: cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, account books, legal papers and steel purses. Second, the Ghost made it himself, "link by link, and yard by yard" (1.131), of his own free will. So the punishment grows out of each selfish choice. The chain also binds him, so that he cannot rest or help anyone. Finally, the chain is a warning, because Scrooge has one too. It was "full as heavy and as long as this, seven Christmas Eves ago." (1.133), and it is heavier now. Scrooge looks for it on the floor and sees nothing. The chain is the weight of every kindness refused.

129 words

What do the phantoms outside the window add to the warning?

Short answer 3 · 5 marks

✓ **Answer.** The phantoms show that Marley's fate is the fate of a whole class of people, and so they make the warning general. First, the air is "filled with phantoms, wandering hither and thither in restless haste, and moaning as they went." (1.171). Each wears a chain like Marley's. Some are chained together, perhaps guilty governments, so Dickens points at public selfishness as well as private. Second, many were known to Scrooge: men of his own kind. Finally, their misery is that they "sought to interfere, for good, in human matters, and had lost the power for ever." (1.171). One weeps

because it cannot help a poor woman and her baby in the street. The lesson is urgent: kindness is possible only in life, and Scrooge is still alive.

130 words

COMMON MISTAKE

The mistake. Counting Marley's Ghost as one of the three Spirits. **The correction.** Marley's Ghost is the messenger. It promises "Three Spirits." (1.158) besides itself, the first "when the bell tolls One." (1.163). It speaks of three nights, but in Stave Five Scrooge says: "The Spirits have done it all in one night." (5.17). **Why it costs marks.** Confusing Marley with the Spirits muddles the plan of the story and every question on the four Ghosts.

Context answer

Stave One, paragraphs 131 to 133

> "I wear the chain I forged in life," replied the Ghost. "I made it link by link, and yard by yard; I girded it on of my own free will, and of my own free will I wore it. Is its pattern strange to you?"
> Scrooge trembled more and more.
> "Or would you know," pursued the Ghost, "the weight and length of the strong coil you bear yourself? It was full as heavy and as long as this, seven Christmas Eves ago. You have laboured on it, since. It is a ponderous chain!"
> (1.131-133)

Reference to context · 200 to 250 words

✓ **Answer.**

Reference. Marley's Ghost speaks these words to Scrooge in Stave One of A Christmas Carol by Charles Dickens. They are in Scrooge's chambers, his rooms, on the night of Christmas Eve.

Context. Marley's Ghost has come through the locked door, dragging a chain of cash-boxes and account books. Scrooge, terrified, has at last said that he believes in it, and now asks why it is fettered.

Explanation. The Ghost says that it made its own chain, link by link, over a lifetime, and put it on by its own free choice. It asks whether the pattern looks strange to Scrooge, because the links are the objects of their shared trade. Then it turns the warning on Scrooge. His own chain was already as heavy and as long seven Christmas Eves ago, when Marley died, and he has added to it since. Scrooge can only tremble.

Critical comment. The speech states the moral law of the whole story in one image. Punishment is not sent from outside. A man builds it himself, choice by choice, and the repeated "of my own free will" (1.131) stresses his responsibility. The words "seven Christmas Eves ago." (1.133) tie Marley's death to the night of the year Scrooge most despises. The lines are also foreshadowing, a hint of what is to come: Scrooge's reform must begin by seeing his own chain. Here the lesson is abstract and frightening; the Spirits will make it visible.

241 words

Objective questions

Choose one answer. Keys are at the end of the book.

6. What is the chain that Marley's Ghost drags made of?

(a) The screws and nuts that held the knocker on
(b) Fifty or sixty fathoms of iron cable
(c) An iron safe and an old fire-guard
(d) Cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds and purses wrought in steel

7. Match the speaker with the line:
A. "Ask me who I was."
B. "There's more of gravy than of grave about you, whatever you are!"
C. "Mankind was my business."
D. "Couldn't I take 'em all at once, and have it over, Jacob?"
Speakers:
1. Scrooge
2. Marley's Ghost

(a) A-2, B-1, C-2, D-1
(b) A-1, B-2, C-2, D-1
(c) A-2, B-1, C-1, D-2
(d) A-2, B-2, C-1, D-1

8. Assertion (A): Marley's Ghost drags a chain.
Reason (R): Scrooge has heard that ghosts in haunted houses are described as dragging chains.

(a) Both A and R are true, and R explains A
(b) Both A and R are true, but R does not explain A
(c) A is true, but R is false
(d) A is false, but R is true

9. Put these events in the order they happen:
I. Every bell in the house rings.
II. Scrooge sees Marley's face in the knocker.
III. The Ghost takes off its bandage and its jaw drops.
IV. The air outside the window fills with phantoms.

(a) II, III, I, IV
(b) I, II, III, IV
(c) II, I, III, IV
(d) I, II, IV, III

10. Statement I: The Ghost tells Scrooge that the first Spirit will come when the bell tolls One.
Statement II: The Ghost says Scrooge's own chain has grown no heavier since Marley died.

(a) Only I is true
(b) Only II is true
(c) Both are true
(d) Neither is true

Keys to the Objective Questions

Unit 1: Marley Was Dead: Scrooge in His Counting-house

1. ✓ **(b)** Seven years. “Mr. Marley has been dead these seven years,” (1.46), and he died on Christmas Eve.

2. ✓ **(c)** A-2, B-1, C-3, D-4. The nephew (1.17), Scrooge (1.50), the clerk (1.72) and the gentleman (1.61).

3. ✓ **(d)** A is false, but R is true. A is false: “But I suppose you must have the whole day.” (1.77); he does call it “not fair” (1.73).

4. ✓ **(a)** III, I, II, IV. The nephew (1.12), the gentlemen (1.44), the carol singer (1.67) and the slide (1.78).

5. ✓ **(c)** Both are true. “Scrooge never painted out Old Marley’s name.” (1.5); the clerk has “fifteen shillings a week,” (1.43).

Unit 2: Marley’s Ghost: “I Wear the Chain I Forged in Life”

6. ✓ **(d)** Cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds and purses wrought in steel. The chain was made “of cash-boxes, keys, padlocks, ledgers, deeds, and heavy purses wrought in steel.” (1.97).

7. ✓ **(a)** A-2, B-1, C-2, D-1. The Ghost (1.103), Scrooge (1.115), the Ghost (1.148) and Scrooge (1.164).

8. ✓ **(b)** Both A and R are true, but R does not explain A. Both are true (1.97, 1.93), but the Ghost wears the chain it “forged in life” (1.131).

9. ✓ **(c)** II, I, III, IV. The knocker (1.80), the bells (1.92), the dropped jaw (1.123), the phantoms (1.171).

10. ✓ **(a)** Only I is true. The first comes “when the bell tolls One.” (1.163); of Scrooge’s chain, “You have laboured on it, since.” (1.133).

Janjua's ENGLISH LIT NOTES

This was a free sample of

A Christmas Carol

CHARLES DICKENS

EXAM EDITION

THE FULL BOOK HAS

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COMING SOON ON AMAZON

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